

Navigator the most suitable for my mom for the simple reason that it is the easiest to use. Moreover, her little experience in using Netscape on Windows would come in handy here.

Setting up Netscape Navigator is a breeze. Just go to **Edit > Preferences** in Netscape Navigator. Later, I accessed Netscape Communicator from the Navigator menu (**Communicator > Messenger**) to configure it as her e-mail client. It is pretty simple to use and set up, and I entered the e-mail address, POP3 and SMTP settings for her account. I also configured Netscape to dial on demand (by writing a script using the diald daemon—a script that I would be happy to share with your mom if she sends me her e-mail ID) the Internet connection whenever my mom tried to browse a site or send/receive a message. I also customised some applets using the KDE Panel to notify my mom with a sound whenever a new message came for her. After some time, I had to make do with the visual notification as she got quite irritated with the beep every 3 minutes. Even otherwise, I set up a dial-up icon on her desktop using KPPP, the GUI dialler in KDE (made it easy for my mom—all she has to do is click on the icon and the modem dials out on its own, and using scripts, sends out the login and password and connects. No need to remember and type in passwords.

Cluttering the desktop

It's easy to create shortcuts in KDE. Right-click on the desktop and select **Create New > Link to Application**. Click on the KDE icon in the 'Properties for Program' desktop dialog box that opens to select the icon you

want for the link. Now give a name for the link in the Program desktop's text box, click on Execute tab, and give the path for the application if you know it, else use the Browse button to find its location. Usually, you should find the application in the directory /usr/bin. Click OK and you're done. Easy, isn't it?

I find Konqueror, the default browser that comes with KDE, a good file manager and it is again very easy to use. When Konqueror opens it directly takes my mom to her home directory, so she also doesn't have much of a problem with directories.

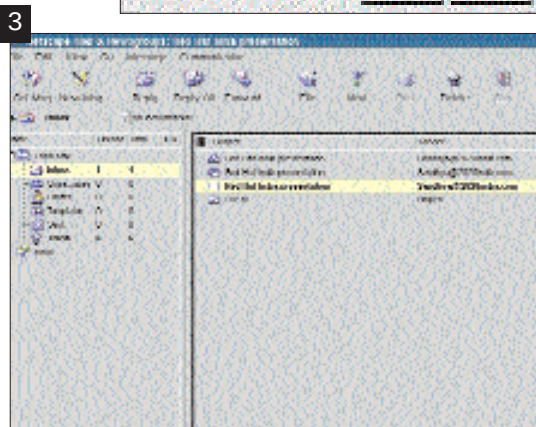
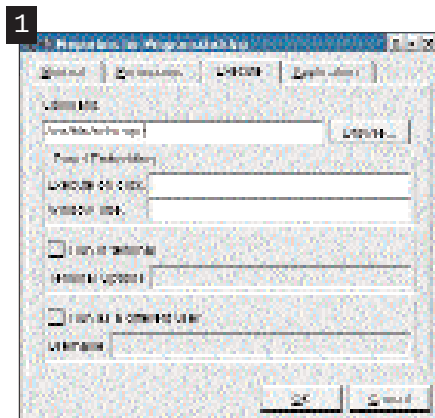
My mother usually has problems



opening different types of files. I normally give her a small briefing when it comes to this. She knows most of the files will be opened with the application with which it is associated. In case of files that cannot be opened by default, she right-clicks on the file and selects the Open with...option from the menu that pops up. I gave her a small tutorial on how to identify the type of application by looking at the file extensions, which she understood quickly. Very soon, she was off making her own associations.

Chatting and opening up

My mom loves to chat, and it makes no



1. Create a shortcut on your desktop
2. Use the Gaim Messenger to access the MSN network
3. Configure Netscape Messenger to access your e-mail account

difference if she can't see her partners physically. She's familiar with the instant messaging phenomenon and has used MSN Messenger and other IMs like Yahoo! and ICQ. Licq is the Linux version of ICQ.

In case of other services such as MSN, Yahoo!, AOL, etc, Gaim is the messenger client to use. This messenger

for Linux has plugins which help log on to MSN, Yahoo!, ICQ, IRC, etc. The default Gaim configuration allows you to use only AOL. To use the other services, you have to add plugins. I added a plugin to log on to MSN by clicking on the Plugins button in Gaim to get the Gaim-Plugins dialog box.

Click on the Load button. This brings up the Gaim-Plugin List.

In the list, select libmsn.so and click OK. The MSN plugin will be added in Gaim. Enter the MSN user ID and password in the main window to log on to MSN. For example, I had created my mom's Hotmail ID as Mothergoose@hotmail.com. I entered Mothergoose as screen name in the Gaim-Login dialog box. She wasn't too happy and put her password as 'mysonisanidiot'.



>Help for the Uninitiated

The best thing about Linux is that almost all the programs are available for free. If you need more programs, just download them off the Net. www.freshmeat.net, www.sourceforge.net and www.rpmfind.net are great places to get started with some really cool programs. Just type in a few words about the kind of application you need in the search area of SourceForge or any of the other sites mentioned here. Or you can use the software

map link in the SourceForge main page to find the kind of application you need. Newbies need help sometimes when they are alone with Tux. Where do they look for it? www.penguinmagazine.com is a site for Linux rookies which should be able to clear most of the doubts. You can use the message board at the site to get answers to most of your questions. Another place where you'll be able to get answers is www.linuxnewbie.org.